Two-Minute Debrief

For the lessons that didn't go as planned. Answer four questions, then paste them into the prompt on page 4 or at choosewise.education/two-minute-debrief. **Run it before you meet the group again.**

Goal

What should students have learned?

Evidence

What did they show? A feeling is fine; counts and patterns are better. No names, no individual results.

Surprise

What turned out differently from the plan? (optional)

Next

What comes next with this group, and when?

Do not include student names or student results in this conversation. Describe what the group showed in counts and patterns.

The loop closes itself: the result of the check becomes the evidence in your next debrief for that group.

One-question check

When the goal has one right answer, such as a calculation, a date or a definition.

Exit ticket
[One question on today's goal, with one right answer]
Example: Solve 4x + 3 = 19.

Microsoft Forms

1. Go to forms.office.com and choose New Quiz.
2. Add a Text question for a written answer, or a Choice question if you give options.
3. In Settings, untick “Record name”.
4. Share the link or show the QR code at the end of the lesson.
5. Open the Responses tab to count right and wrong answers.

Google Forms

1. Go to forms.google.com and start a blank quiz.
2. Add a Short answer question and set the correct answer in the answer key.
3. In Settings, set “Collect email addresses” to “Do not collect”.
4. Send the link, or show it as a QR code.
5. Open the Responses tab to see how many got it right.

On paper: a slip with no name line. Sort into two piles, right and not yet, before you leave the room.

Hinge question

When you know the mistakes students tend to make. Each wrong option shows one of them.

Exit ticket
[One question] A … B … C … D …
Example: Where does most of the mass of a dry log come from?
A the soil B water C the air D sunlight

Microsoft Forms

1. Go to forms.office.com and choose New Quiz, so Forms can mark the right answer.
2. Add a Choice question and paste the question and options. Tick the correct option.
3. In Settings, untick “Record name”.
4. Share the link or show the QR code at the end of the lesson.
5. Open the Responses tab: it shows how many chose each option.

Google Forms

1. Go to forms.google.com and start a blank quiz.
2. Add a Multiple choice question, paste the question and options, and set the answer key.
3. In Settings, set “Collect email addresses” to “Do not collect”.
4. Send the link, or show it as a QR code.
5. Open the Responses tab: the chart shows the counts for each option.

Without forms: students hold up A, B, C or D on fingers or cards at the same time, and you count.

Confidence + one question

When you want to find students who are sure but wrong. They need a different follow-up from those who know they are unsure.

> Exit ticket
> 1. How sure are you that you can [today's goal]? 1 not sure, 2 a little sure, 3 quite sure, 4 very sure
> 2. [One check question]

Microsoft Forms

1. Go to forms.office.com and choose New Quiz.
2. Add a Rating question from 1 to 4 for how sure students are.
3. Add a Choice or Text question for the check, and mark the right answer.
4. In Settings, untick “Record name”.
5. Open the Responses tab and compare how sure they were with how many got it right.

Google Forms

1. Go to forms.google.com and start a blank quiz.
2. Add a Linear scale question from 1 to 4 for how sure students are.
3. Add the check question and set the answer key.
4. In Settings, set “Collect email addresses” to “Do not collect”.
5. Open the Responses tab and compare the two charts.

On paper: students write the number and the answer on one slip. Make four piles by number, then check the answers in piles 3 and 4 first.

Explain it in one sentence

When the goal is understanding rather than recall. Sort the answers into three piles: got it, partly, not yet.

> Exit ticket
> In one sentence, explain [today's key idea].
> Example: In one sentence, explain why we have day and night.

Microsoft Forms

1. Go to forms.office.com and choose New Form.
2. Add a Text question and paste the question.
3. In Settings, untick “Record name”.
4. Share the link or show the QR code at the end of the lesson.
5. Open the Responses tab, read the answers and count got it, partly and not yet.

Google Forms

1. Go to forms.google.com and start a blank form.
2. Add a Paragraph question and paste the question.
3. In Settings, set “Collect email addresses” to “Do not collect”.
4. Send the link, or show it as a QR code.
5. Open the Responses tab, read the answers and count got it, partly and not yet.

On paper: a slip with no name line. Three piles on your desk while students pack up.

WITHOUT THE WEBSITE

Your debrief prompt

Fill in the blanks, then type the prompt into any AI tool: Copilot, Gemini, ChatGPT or Claude. With no surprise, write "None given". Faster online: the builder at choosewise.education/two-minute-debrief fills this in and can save debriefs for the end of the day.

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Do not include student names or student results in this conversation.

You are helping a Grade _____ teacher think through a lesson with _____
that did not go as planned. Base everything on what the teacher writes below, and tie
every point to this lesson's content.

Goal: _____
Evidence: _____
_____
Surprise: _____
Next: _____

Reply in plain text, no tables, in exactly this format:
LIKELY CAUSES: two possible explanations, numbered 1 and 2, each tied to this lesson's
content, and what would tell them apart. Look beyond the first explanation: missing prior
knowledge, too much new at once, a common misconception, a task that did not make students
think about the goal, or too little practice.
NEXT LESSON: one concrete move aimed at the more likely cause, with minutes. Not "re-
teach".
CHECK FIRST: one quick question or task, written exactly as students will see it, and when
to move on, for example "Move on if about 4 in 5 get it right". If the evidence is only a
feeling, also say what to look at to turn the feeling into evidence.
ONE QUESTION: one question back to the teacher, to think further.
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ONCE A WEEK

Your weekly roll-up prompt

Write one line per debrief from the week: date, group, goal, evidence, surprise and next. Rows from the unit journal work too. The roll-up finds patterns one lesson wouldn't show.

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Do not include student names or student results in this conversation.

You are helping a teacher look back on a week of lesson debriefs. Each debrief has a date,
a group, a goal, evidence, a surprise and a next step. Some evidence starts with the
result of a check from an earlier lesson.

Debriefs:
_____
_____
_____
_____

Reply in plain text, no tables, in exactly this format:
PATTERNS: up to three patterns across the week that one lesson would not show. After each,
name the debriefs it comes from by date and group.
WHAT WORKED: any change whose later check showed improvement. If there are no check
results yet, write "Not enough check results yet".
ONE CHANGE FOR NEXT WEEK: one concrete change to the teacher's routine.
ONE QUESTION: one question back to the teacher.
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A WORKED DEBRIEF

Two-step equations · 8B maths, Grade 8

THE TEACHER WRITES

Goal
Solve two-step equations such as 3x + 5 = 20.

Evidence
On question 2 of the exit ticket, 11 of 27 divided by 3 first but left the + 5 unchanged. Several wrote x + 5 = 20 ÷ 3.

Surprise
Energy was low after lunch, and the new notation took longer than I planned.

Next
Word problems with two-step equations, Thursday.

THE AI REPLIES

Likely causes
1. Students are not secure in how inverse operations work on the whole equation: they divide by 3 first, which is allowed, and forget that the + 5 must then be divided too. If this is the cause, the same error shows up on every equation where they divide first.
2. Too much new at once: the notation and the two-step method arrived in the same lesson, so working memory ran out. If this is the cause, students get one-step equations right but slip as soon as both steps are needed.

Next lesson
Open with one worked example of 3x + 5 = 20, saying each step aloud, then one half-finished example where students do the last step, then two to try on their own (8 min).

Check first
Solve 4x + 3 = 19. Show both steps.
Move on to word problems if about 4 in 5 get x = 4 and every step keeps the equation balanced.

One question
What will you do on Thursday with the students who still divide first?

WHY IT WORKS

The research behind the debrief

Strong: Meta-analyses of classroom studies show that teaching this way improves learning. **Promising:** Controlled studies show gains, but results are mixed, small in number or dependent on context. **Framework:** A useful structure for planning, with no intervention studies behind it as a method.

Formative assessment: acting on what students show Strong

Black & Wiliam's 1998 review made the case that formative assessment raises achievement, and a 2024 meta-analysis of 118 K-12 studies confirms a positive, more modest average effect (Yao et al. 2024). A whole-school EEF trial found a similar, real effect at scale.

Feedback that moves learning Strong

Feedback is among the best-evidenced approaches in the EEF Teaching and Learning Toolkit. A 2020 meta-analysis finds a medium average effect with large variation: feedback that carries rich information about the task and how to improve works much better than praise, rewards or punishment (Wisniewski, Zierer & Hattie 2020).

Worked examples and cognitive load Strong

Cognitive load theory rests on decades of replicated experiments. The worked-example effect is one of its most robust findings, confirmed in a 2023 meta-analysis, and it fades as students gain expertise (Sweller, van Merriënboer & Paas 2019; Barbieri et al. 2023).

Hinge questions Framework

A hinge question is one multiple-choice question at a key point in the lesson, where each wrong option shows a known misconception, so the teacher can decide in a minute whether to move on. It builds on the all-student responses Wiliam (2011) describes, such as letter cards everyone holds up at once. Lab studies with university students show that multiple-choice items with plausible wrong options make students retrieve as well as open questions do (Little et al. 2012). The hinge question itself has had little direct testing in classrooms.

Structured teacher reflection Framework

Reflecting on a lesson in a set structure is widely recommended in teacher education, but no meta-analysis shows that it improves student learning as a method on its own. What makes a difference is what reflection leads to: teachers acting on evidence of what their students learned (Timperley et al. 2007). That is why every debrief starts from the goal and the evidence.

Sources and links: choosewise.education/two-minute-debrief